

Chiron's Teaching and his Pupils

In *Fastii*, the poet Ovid argues in an ambiguous line “morum, quos fecit, praemia doctor habet (the teacher has the prizes of the characters which he made)” (l.410). One interpretation of this line is that it summarizes the previous interactions between Chiron and Achilles. Since “saepe manus aegras manibus fingeat amicis (often he [Chiron] was stroking the sick hands [of Achilles] with his friendly hands)” (l.409), the narrator observes, “stabat, ut ante patrem, lacrimis perfusus Achilles: / sic flendus Peleus, si moreretur erat (Achilles having been poured through with tears, was standing as if before his father, thus Peleus had to be wept for, if he [Peleus] were dying).” (ll.407--8). However, one may also read that Chiron suffers from the result of his ways of teaching. One question naturally springs from this implication: Is Chiron really a great teacher? The question is remarkable because it inspects the natures of mythological heroes and explores the influence of early education on children, especially the ones seemingly destined to glorious deeds. The answer would open up further questions: what factors contribute to the problems of his education, and is there a common pattern of his failures?

In Greco-Roman mythology, Chiron is generally considered a wise centaur successful in nurturing youth. In Book XI of Homer's *Iliad*, Eurypylus calls Chiron “[the] most righteous of all the centaurs” (l.831). Euripides in his *Iphigenia in Aulis* further expands upon the recognition of Chiron's instructions. In order to convince the suspecting mother Clytaemnestra of Achilles's integrity, Agamemnon comments: “Chiron taught him, / that he might never learn the customs of / evil men” (ll.708--9). Even Clytaemnestra, particular about her daughter's marriage, feels satisfied with the wise centaur's teaching: “I would say a wise teacher, but / Peleus giving him that teacher was wiser still” (ll.709--10). Later in the play Achilles also openly shows pride in his upbringing: “I was educated by the most god-fearing / of all, by Chiron, and it was from him /

I've learned to act in singleness of heart" (Il.926--8). Moreover, many famous Greek heroes are once Chiron's pupils, including Heracles, the accomplisher of Twelve Labors, Telamon, the attacker who almost surpasses Heracles in the assault of Troy, Theseus, the slayer of Minotaur, and Jason, the leader of Argonauts. In Book I of *Argonautica*, Apollonius of Rhodē describes the scene where Chiron greets his former students among the fleet members: "And there came down from the mountain-top to the sea Chiron, son of Philyra, and where the white surf broke he dipped his feet, and, often waving with his broad hand, cried out to them at their departure, 'Good speed and a sorrowless home-return!'" (1.554). Given the fame of his pupils, one may argue that Chiron's education is successful in preparing youthful and ambitious students to embark on glorious deeds.

However, a closer inspection reveals one disturbing case: when Chiron instructs these heroes to accomplish magnificent feats with might and prowess, he fails to teach them morals effectively. Consequently, many of his pupils are known for deep flaws in their personalities. In particular, they share an unrestrained appetite for carnal pleasures, whether legal or disreputable. For example, Jason, the leader of Argonauts, triggers the unquenchable rages of Medea when he abandons her and prefers the beautiful bride Glauce from Corinth. The excessive sexual desire proves to be the downfall of Heracles. In Sophocles's *Women of Trachis*, Deianeira feels greatly perturbed on hearing that her husband Heracles has laid siege to the city of Oechalia only to capture the girl Iole as a slave. Fearing the rivalry over Heracles's affection from a foreign woman, Deianeira remembers the dying words of the hydra and thus dyes a robe with the monster's blood in order to ensure her husband's faithfulness. As soon as he puts on the poisonous gown, Heracles is overcome by the stinging afflictions. He orders himself to be burnt alive to stop the ceaseless pain. Moreover, in Book I of *Iliad*, Achilles's passion for Briseis along

with his disgust over Agamemnon's arrogance overcome the sense of responsibilities and the burning desire for glory. Despite Agamemnon's and Ajax's separate attempts for reconciliation, Achilles simply stays in the tent and watches the Greek army being routed, even though once the young hero's burning desire for glory surmounts the high regard for life. Before his expedition to Troy, when staying hidden among Lycomedes's daughters in Skyros, Achilles wrongfully employs Chiron's arts to seduce Deidamia: "modo dulcia notae / fila lyrae tenuesque modos et carmina monstrat / Chironis ducitque manum digitosque sonanti / infringit citharae, nunc occupat ora canentis / et ligat amplexus et mille per oscula laudat (Now he shows the sweet strings of the familiar lyre, delicate measures and songs of Chiron, and leads his hand and strokes the fingers on the sounding lyre; now he seizes the mouth of the singing girl and binds embraces and praises her through a thousand kisses)" (Il.572--6). Fervent with his yearning, he disregards the etiquettes of being a guest and instead forcefully rapes Deidamia: "Sic ait et densa noctis gavisus in umbra / tempestiva suis torpere silentia furtis / vi potitur votis et toto pectore veros / admovet amplexus (Thus he speaks and having rejoiced that in the thick shadow of the night a timely silence is numb to his own tricks. He obtains the pledges with force and brings up true embraces with his whole heart)" (Il.640--3). In Dante's *Inferno*, because of the unprincipled lust, Achilles has to suffer indefinitely in the second circle of Hell. The consistent excessive lust among his pupils opens up the question whether Chiron has constructively taught his students on the subject matter of families.

One prominent example of insatiable sensuality is Theseus, who unwillingly admits the notoriety of his own sex misdeeds: "sidera et manes et undas scelere complevi meo: / amplius sors nulla restat; regna me norunt tria (I have filled the stars and underworld shadows and waves with my crime: No lot remains further; three kingdoms know me)" (Il.1211--2). Having defeated

Minotaur and then carried off Ariadne with the promise of marriage along with her sister Phaedra, Theseus, however, reneges on his oaths and instead viciously leaves sleeping Ariadne alone on the island of Naxos. Catullus recounts the Ariadne's terror on finding herself abandoned: "Namque fluentisono prospectans litore Diae / Thesea cedentem celeri cum classe tuetur / Indomitos in corde gerens Ariadna furores, / Necdum etiam sese quae visit visere credit, / Ut pote fallaci quae tunc primum excita somno / Desertam in sola miseram se cernat harena. / Immemor at iuvenis fugiens pellit vada remis, / Irrita ventosae linquens promissa procellae. (And for gazing out from the shore of Dia resounding with waves, Ariadne sees Theseus leaving along with a fast fleet, bearing untamed rages in heart. She still not yet believes that she sees the things which she herself has seen, and inasmuch as she then at first having been roused from the deceitful sleep, sees that she herself miserable had been deserted on the lonely sand. However, the forgetful young man fleeing the fords, beats [the water] with oars, leaving behind the void things having been promised to the windy gale" (ll.52--9). When the Greeks sail for Troy, deserting Philoctetes on Lemnos is generally regarded as an unforgivable crime. In Sophocles's *Philoctetes*, even Odysseus himself concedes that the decision is dishonorable. Still, Odysseus at least refrains from taking the famed bow and arrows in order that Philoctetes may still hunt for food. In this way, giving up a defenseless sleeping maiden on a forlorn island without any supply is even more egregious. Catullus envisions a grim doom for Ariadne: "pro quo dilaceranda feris dabor alitibusque / praeda, neque iniacta tumulabor mortua terra (in return for this thing, I having to be torn into pieces will be given as a prey to wild beasts and birds, and I, dead, will not be covered with a burial mound with earth having been thrown upon)" (ll.152--3). If Dionysus had not found her and pitied her, the horrid prediction might have come true. Ariadne, having ascended into the sky as a goddess, becomes a perpetual witness and accuser of Theseus's crimes

in the heaven. Unabashed by his deception towards Ariadne, Theseus befriends Pirithous and the proud companions pledge to marry daughters of Zeus. Having set eyes on Helen, the most beautiful woman in the world, Theseus tears her from her parents' home and intends to marry her when she reaches puberty. Undaunted by this blatant transgression, he and Pirithous plan and then attempt an even more scandalous sacrilege, namely, the abduct of Persephone, the wife of Hades, from the underworld. Therefore, Theseus's heinous atrocities become well-known among the dead as well. In Seneca's *Phaedra*, the unhappy eponymous heroine, having been confined in the marital house while desiring freedom, complains about Theseus's faithlessness: "profugus en coniunx abest / praestatque nuptae quam solet Theseus fidem. (Behold, Theseus, my fugitive husband is away, and he offers to his wife his faithfulness to which he is accustomed)" (ll.91--2). She continues to hurl reproaches at Theseus's profane expedition: "pergit furoris socius, haud illum timor / pudorque tenuit: stupra et illicitos toros / Acheronte in imo quaerit Hippolyti pater. (He goes on as an ally of madness. By no means fear and decency held that man: The father of Hippolytus seeks fornications and illicit beds in the deepest Acheron)" (ll.96--98). In Euripides's *Hippolytus*, When Theseus eventually summons Poseidon to kill the eponymous hero out of the jealousy for love, Artemis appears and launches a fierce reprimand: "But you've been proven wicked both in his [Poseidon's] eyes / and mine in that you did not stay for oaths / nor voice of oracles, nor put to proof, / nor let long time investigate—too quickly / you hurled the curses at your son and killed him" (ll.1321--4). Even Poseidon, Theseus's father, becomes indignant at the outrage, leaving the Athenian king a complete outcast from the world. The Syrian writer Lucian satirizes Theseus's obsession with sex. In *A True Story*, even though Theseus has never been Helen's husband, the narrator witnesses "a wrangle between Theseus and Menelaus over which

of them Helen should live with” (37). Theseus lost his case because he “had a number of other wives, the Amazon girl and Minos’ daughters” (37).

Unlike many other pupils of Chiron who are mainly known for marvelous exploits, Theseus is also a political leader ruling Athens. On the night Aegeus sleeps with Aethra, she wades to the island of Sphairia and bedded Poseidon. Accordingly, both Aegeus and Poseidon are fathers of Theseus. Since the title basileus (βασιλεύς) of Athens must be inherited by its citizen while a foreigner can work his way at most up to a tyrannos (τύραννος). Therefore, Theseus is both a basileus and a tyrannos of Athens at the same time. In fact, his personality is also intricately related to this duality. On the one hand, Theseus is a benevolent basileus, accommodating unfortunate friends from other lands. In Euripides’s *Heracles*, after Heracles has murdered his wife Megara and their children, and has beaten up Amphitryon, his foster father, Theseus is willing to offer a shelter to the frenzied hero. Likewise, in Sophocles’s *Oedipus at Colonus*, Theseus offers a refuge to the Theban tyrant who has fulfilled the grim oracle by killing Laius and marrying Jocasta. Moreover, Theseus sends his two sons to rescue Oedipus’s two daughters from Creon. In *Phaedra*, Theseus’s entrance seems both unassuming and sympathetic. On the other hand, however, as Frederick Ahl observes, “His first reactions to Phaedra’s plight seem very husbandly and consoling. But then there is a sudden shift: he threatens to torture the nurse. The humane charm is gone and the tyrant emerges” (41). This tyrannical nature becomes more manifest when Theseus shamelessly congratulates his own violence against his former Amazonian wife: “iam iam superno numini grates ago, / quod icta nostra cecidit Antiope manu, / quod non ad antra Stygia descendens tibi / matrem reliqui (now I give thanks to the heavenly divinity, because Antiope having been hit by our hand fell, because I, descending towards Stygian caves, did not leave behind your mother to you” (ll.926--9). In addition to the cruelty,

Theseus frequently acts rashly, bringing disasters to both himself and people around. In his haste desertion of Ariadne, Theseus forgets to change the sail, causing his heartbroken father to jump into the sea. Similarly, on hearing the rape accusation from Phaedra, Theseus fails to collect the evidence or organize a fair trial. Instead, he is enraged on finding the sword of Hippolytus and unhesitantly curses him with the grimmest evil. As Frederick Ahl comments, “Theseus may have reason to be suspicious of stepmothers and their jealousies, since he had a particularly murderous stepmother, Medea. ... In our play, however, Theseus forgets the lesson of his childhood. The sword, a token which saved him from his stepmother, now becomes evidence offered by his son’s stepmother which condemns Hippolytus to death” (41). Therefore, in *Phaedra*, before her suicide, the eponymous heroine accuses the once glorious king who has turned into a brutal tyrant: “O dure Theseu semper, o numquam tuis / tuto reverse! natus et genitor nece / reditus tuos luere; pervertis domum / amore semper coniugum aut odio nocens (O always harsh Theseus, o [Theseus] having never returned to your people without danger! Your son and your father paid your returns with death; you, always harmful, overturn your home, by the love or hate for your spouse)” (ll.1164--1167). Unfortunately, the brutal tyrannos triumphs over the benign basileus, and Theseus falls into an endless remorse.

Similar to Theseus who wields the power impulsively, Telamon, another student of Chiron, allows pride to rule over reasons. In Sophocles’s *Ajax*, after the eponymous hero commits suicide out of the anger over the denial of Achilles’s equipment and the shame over the frenzied killing of Greek livestock, Teucer envisions a harsh homecoming reception by Telemon: “What will he not say? What reproach will he spare me? / ‘Bastard, born from the war spear, wretched coward, / deserter and abandoner’—of you, / dear Ajax! Or perhaps he will suggest / I did it out of treachery, so that I / might get your house and power by your death” (ll.1012--7).

Although he immediately runs to Ajax's tent on hearing Calchas's prophecy, Teucer is not fast enough to stop the suicide. Despite his endeavors, Teucer imagines his forlorn future because of Ajax's death: "In the end I'll be / cast into exile and denied my country, / a slave in his account, no more a free man" (Il.1018--20). This prediction turns out to be true when Teucer is convicted and then disowned by Telamon for the failure to bring back the corpse and armor. This sentence is unjustified because had Teucer not been present, Ajax's body would have been thrown away to the wild beasts; in order to bury his half-brother, Teucer risks his own life. Moreover, Telamon was once greatly worried by the lack of heirs. It was Heracles's prayers to Zeus that helped Telamon to beget Ajax. However, when banishing Teucer from Salamis, Telamon seems to forget that with Ajax having been killed, there is no heir for the throne again. Probably Telamon might choose to adopt Ajax's son Eurysaces with the war-slave Tecmessa. Nevertheless, in terms of birth, Eurysaces does not have a stronger claim to the kingship of Salamis than Teucer, since they both are born from war-slaves. Moreover, since Telamon is already feeble with old age, it may be difficult to defend Eurysaces and Tecmessa from people desiring to share the power of Salamis. After all, in Euripides's *Andromache*, the senile hero Peleus finds it hard to stop Menelaus and Hermione from harassing the eponymous captive-slave and her son. It is only Thetis's appearance at the end of the play that saves the mother and the son, who is the only descendant of the house of Peleus. Therefore, by unjustly expelling Teucer, Telamon not only reveals his despotic nature but also endangers the future of his own house.

While most of Chiron's students do not have the fortune to become kings, many of them still suffer from incompetent thinking which is unbecoming to their valor. When Achilles allows his own pride overcomes his clear judgment of the war, he indiscreetly dooms his best friend Patroclus by sending him into the unfavorable battles. Similarly, in *Ajax*, Calchas recounts that

the eponymous hero frequently lets the confidence in valor overcome the patience to listen to well-intentioned advice. Calchas reproaches Ajax for replying with “a senseless boast” to Telamon’s well-intentioned advice: “Father, with god’s help even a worthless man / could triumph. I propose without that help / to win my prize of fame” (ll.766--9). Worse still, Calchas points out that Ajax’s arrogance induces him to “[win] from the goddess hatred and fierce anger” with “words to shudder at, not speak”: “Goddess, ... / go stand beside the other Greeks; help them. / For where I’m stationed, no enemy will break through” (ll.773--5). Both Achilles and Ajax err in rational judgments on account of their overconfidence in their own courage, while the experienced Argonaut leader Jason overlooks risks when eager to marry a new bride. In Euripides’s *Medea*, in a haste to marry Glauce, Jason fails to consider possible dangers from his abandoned wife facing a severe exile. In his conversation with Medea, even though he detects her strange behaviors: “[her] eyes engulfed with glistening tears” and her “turning pallid cheeks away” (ll.921--922), Jason still naively believes that she could be reconciled to his new wife. Knowing that Medea can do anything to achieve her ends, including dismembering her brother to stop the pursuing army and tricking the unsuspecting daughters into killing their father Pelias, Jason should have been more cautious, especially when her facial expressions betray a more complex emotion.

On the whole, since the crimes impelled by excessive sexual desires, the tyrannical nature in ruling the country and the lack of reasoning are shared by many pupils of Chiron, one may assume that his education in these fields are unsatisfactory. However, it might be ill-advised to attribute all faults of the disciples to the teacher, because students can pick up terrible habits after the early education, or sometimes the instructor is simply unable to alter the ingrained evil. For example, it is arguable that the crimes of overthrowing the democracy by his students, Critias

and Theramenes and the depraved life of Alcibiades swayed Athenians' decision in Socrates's trial and helped pass the severe death penalty. Nevertheless, the foundations for the death penalty, especially the charge of corrupting the youth, were shaky. In particular, Xenophon tries to point out in his *Apology* that Alcibiades had always been debauched, since long before meeting Socrates. In fact, one important aspect of the early education of children that Chiron himself is unable to offer is the presence of father. When sending their infant children to Chiron, the fathers have to separate themselves from providing parental cares. Therefore, every pupil of Chiron suffers to some degree the unfulfilled fatherhood.

In ancient Greek society, fathers are the core of households and assume the main responsibility of supporting the family and warding off transgressions from outsiders. The absence or the demise of adult male family members usually causes irremediable decline or even abrupt collapse. In the Book XXII of *Iliad*, when Andromache sees Hector's body being dragged away by Achilles, she immediately envisions a dismal future for her son Astyanax: "The day that robs a child of his parents severs him from his own kind; his head is bowed, his cheeks are wet with tears, and he will go about destitute among the friends of his father, plucking one by the cloak and another by the shirt" (Il.490--4). In her lamentation, Andromache regards Hector's death as the loss of parents (in the plural form) for Astyanax, even though she is still alive at that time. Furthermore, she predicts that Astyanax would become a social outcast without Hector "Then one whose parents are alive will drive him from the table with blows and angry words. 'Out with you,' he will say, 'you have no father here'" (Il.497--8). Even worse than her anticipation, Astyanax is summarily executed by being thrown off a high tower after Troy falls. In Seneca's *Trojan Women*, despite Andromache's eager hope that Hector's spirit might somehow save Astyanax, she cannot stop Odysseus from taking away her son and she herself

becomes a slave to Neoptolemus. The hope imbued in the name Astyanax, “the protector of the city,” which Trojans choose to honor his father, becomes an unfortunate misnomer when deceased Hector could not guard family or Troy. This pattern of vulnerability without the father in the family persists when Andromache becomes a slave. In *Andromache*, the eponymous heroine is entirely powerless against the threats and persecutions from Hermione and Menelaus, when her master, also the father of her son, is away from the home. In the opening scene, she complains about her helpless situation without Neoptolemus’s presence: “The one who served to begat him serves for nothing / In the hour of need---no help at all to his baby. / He’s off at Delphi making amends to Apollo” (ll.49--51). As Frederick Ahl observes, the Greek word *physis* (*φύσις*), meaning “nature,” gives an image of “begetting” or “sprouting” as opposed to *natura* which is connected to “giving birth” (4). In response to the Furies’ argument that Orestes should die for killing his mother Clytaemnestra, Apollo claims in Aeschylus’s *Eumenides* that “The mother is no parent of that which is called / her child, but only nurse of the new-planted seed / that grows. The parent is he who mounts” (ll.658--660). Therefore, in ancient Greek society, the father, instead of the mother, is the true parent of the child and thus assumes the responsibility of education the kid.

Nevertheless, due to frequent wars or the obligations towards the country, fathers are frequently absent and thus mothers take charge of children’s upbringing. For example, Odysseus leaves a baby Telemachus in Ithaca when setting out to Troy. In this way, Penelope naturally becomes the nurturer of Telemachus. In *Iphigenia in Aulis*, before the fleet departs, Agamemnon also entrusts infant Orestes to Clytaemnestra: “Now must you take this little son of ours / and journey home” (ll.22--3). Moreover, after Achilles is given to Chiron, it seems Thetis, rather than Peleus, is the more active parent to ensure the safety of the young Thessalian kid. In Book IX of

Iliad, Achilles recollects Thetis's warning of danger: "My mother Thetis tells me that there are two ways in which I may meet my end. If I stay here and fight, I shall not return alive but my name will live for ever: whereas if I go home my name will die, but it will be long ere death shall take me" (Il.410--413). In Book I of Statius's *Achilleid*, undaunted by Poseidon's rejection to sink Paris's fleet to stop the Trojan War, Thetis intently searches for new ways to save her son: "Dixerat. illa gravi vultum demissa repulsa, / quae iam excire fretum et ratibus bellare parabat / Iliacis, alios animo commenta paratus, / tristis ad Haemonias detorquet bracchia terras (He had said. That woman [Thetis] having been sent down with respect to the face by the heavy rebuff, who was already preparing to rouse the sea and fight with the Illian ships, having devised other preparations in mind, sad, turns her lower arms towards Haemonian lands)" (Il.95--8). It is she, not Peleus, who persuades Achilles to hide among the girls to avoid discovery: "quin et metuenda propinquant / tempora et extremis admota pericula metis. / cedamus, paulumque animos submitte viriles / atque habitus dignare meos (However, and the times having to be feared draw near and dangers have moved towards outmost ends. Let us yield and [do thou] lower your manly minds a little and deed worthy my clothes)" (Il.257--60). Therefore, for some pupils of Chiron, although not experiencing fatherly affections, they sometimes do enjoy the attentions from mothers.

Having not sufficiently experienced fatherly love, many of Chiron's pupils later also enter dysfunctional parent-child relations. As has been discussed above, Theseus believes in groundless accusations, invoking dire curses upon Hippolytus; Telamon undeservingly convicts Teucer, banishing an eligible heir to the throne; Heracles saves his children from Lycus, but only to murder them himself in a fit of madness. In Seneca's *Medea*, as Frederick Ahl comments, "The only self-justification he [Jason] offers is that love for his children, not fear for his life,

makes him abandon Medea” (38). Fully aware that the stepmother Creusa is unlikely to treat his sons kindly, however, Jason shamelessly uses protecting them as an excuse of coveting the beauty of the young bride: “Regina natis exulum, afflictis potens (A queen for the sons of exiles, powerful for them having been crushed)” (l.509). Jason’s treachery eventually brings about the death of both his sons, despite his offer of his own life in exchange for Medea’s mercy: “Per numen omne perque communes fugas / torosque, quos non nostra violavit fides, / iam parce nato. si quod est crimen, meum est: / me dedo morti; noxium macta caput (By all divinity and by our common flights and our marriage beds which our faithfulness has not violated, now spare your son. But if there is charge, it is mine: I give myself to death; slaughter the guilty head” (ll.1002--5). It is probable that altering the harm of absent fathers is beyond Chiron’s abilities.

In conclusion, Chiron is a successful teacher in preparing young students for heroic deeds, but may fail to fully imbue them with high moralities fitting for those feats. As a possible result, many of his pupils suffer from excessive sexual desires, tyrannical natures and incompetent thinking. Despite his teaching skills, Chiron cannot make up for the absence of fatherly love in the teaching, whereas fathers are the centers of families and true parents of children in ancient Greek society. It is ironic that the shared shortcomings such as unquenchable lust and tendency towards bloodshed are characteristic to centaurs, even though Chiron is always described as one free from these evils. Statius highlights this distinction in *Achilleid*: “at intra / Centauri stabula alta patent, non aequa nefandis / fratribus: hic hominum nullos experta cruores / spicula nec truncae bellis genialibus orni / aut consanguineos fracti crateres in hostes, / sed pharetrae insontes et inania terga ferarum (However, inside the high stalls of the centaur lie open, not like his wicked brothers: here there are no arrows having experienced gores of humans, nor trunks of the ash-tree having been shattered in nuptial festive wars or mixing bowls having been

shattered against kindred enemies but guiltless quivers and empty hides of wild beasts” (Il.110--5). Is it possible that Chiron’s pupils learn these immoral habits from visiting centaurs? After all, before Chiron is mortally hurt by the poisonous arrow, other centaurs having been routed flee to his dwelling. Therefore, Chiron is not entirely cut off from other primitive centaurs. Although the possible negative influences from his visitors should not be considered the failure in Chiron’s teaching, the fathers sending their children to this wise centaur should have foreseen these harmful interactions.

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